Newsom Signs Nation's First Law Banning Ultra-Processed Foods From School Lunches

October 10, 2025 | India West (USA)
Author: The Author | Section: Food | 226 Words
OpenURL Link

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LOS ANGELES, CA – Governor Gavin Newsom on October 9 signed AB 1264, a groundbreaking law making California the first state in the nation to phase out ultra-processed foods from school meals.

The law, authored by Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D–San Fernando Valley), defines what qualifies as ultra-processed and directs schools to remove the most concerning products from their menus over time. It builds on Newsom's broader efforts to protect children's health — including earlier bans on toxic food dyes and universal free school meals.

"California has never waited for Washington or anyone else to lead on kids' health," said Newsom. "This first-in-the-nation law makes sure every student has access to healthy, delicious meals that help them thrive."."

The measure comes as health experts warn of rising rates of prediabetes and obesity among youth. According to the CDC, nearly one in three teenagers between 12 and 19 years old is prediabetic.

Gabriel praised the governor's action as "a historic step toward protecting our children from harmful additives," adding that California is "once again leading the nation with a bipartisan, science-based approach."

California's leadership in school nutrition now spans a universal meals program, a Farm to School initiative connecting classrooms with local growers, and strict bans on sodas and caffeine in K–12 campuses.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Author, T. (2025, October 10). Newsom Signs Nation's First Law Banning Ultra-Processed Foods From School Lunches*India West (USA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1A3A59BD05D2EBC8.